Solutions: Optimization

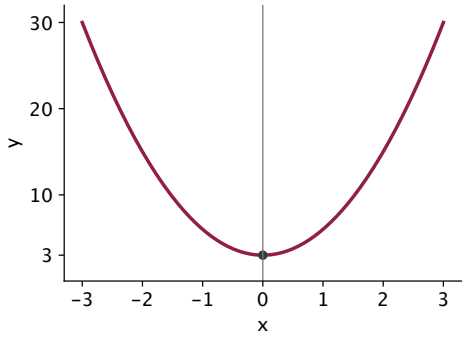
ECON 441: Introduction to Mathematical Economics — Instructor: Div Bhagia

Exercise 9.2

1. (c) $y = 3x^2 + 3$

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = 6x = 0 \implies x^* = 0$$

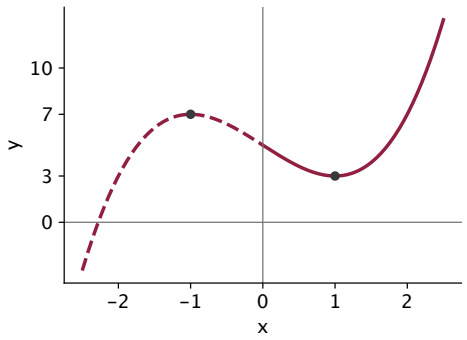
In the immediate neighborhood of 0, $dy/dx < 0$ for $x < 0$ and $dy/dx > 0$ for $x > 0$. The slope changes sign from negative to positive, so the function is decreasing to the left of 0 and increasing to the right: $f(0) = 3$ is a relative minimum. The second derivative confirms this: $d^2y/dx^2 = 6 > 0$.



2. (a) $y = x^3 - 3x + 5$

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = 3x^2 - 3 = 0 \implies x^* = \pm 1$$

The derivative $3(x^2 - 1)$ is negative on the immediate left of 1 (for example at 0.9) and positive on the immediate right (at 1.1), so there is a relative minimum at $x = 1$. It is positive on the immediate left of -1 and negative on the right, so there would be a relative maximum at $x = -1$. But the domain is $[0, \infty)$, so -1 is not admissible. The only stationary value is the relative minimum $f(1) = 3$. The second-derivative test gives the same answer: $d^2y/dx^2 = 6x$, which is $6 > 0$ at $x = 1$.

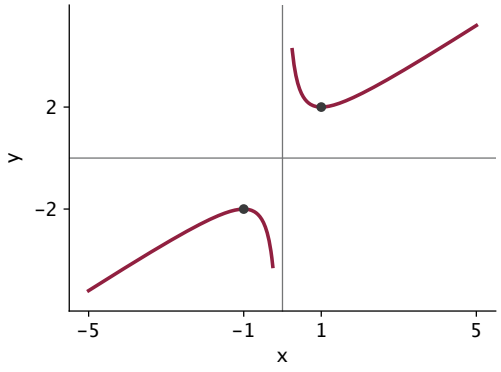


3. $f(x) = x + 1/x$

$$f'(x) = 1 - \frac{1}{x^2} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; x^* = \pm 1$$

The derivative, $(x^2 - 1)/x^2$, is negative on the immediate left of 1 and positive on the immediate right, so $f(1) = 2$ is a relative minimum. It is positive on the immediate left of -1 and negative on the right, so $f(-1) = -2$ is a relative maximum.

The relative maximum, -2, is lower than the relative minimum, 2. This is not a contradiction: these are *relative* extrema, each compared only with nearby points on its own branch of the graph. The function is not defined at $x = 0$, and the two branches never meet.



4. $T = \phi(x)$

(a) $M = \phi'(x)$ and $A = \phi(x)/x$.

(b) At an extremum of A,

$$A' = \frac{\phi'(x)\,x - \phi(x)}{x^2} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \phi'(x^*) = \frac{\phi(x^*)}{x^*}$$

that is, $M = A$.

(c) The marginal curve must cross the average curve at the point where the average curve reaches its extremum (its lowest point for a U-shaped average cost curve).

(d) The elasticity of T is

$$\varepsilon = \frac{\phi'(x)\,x}{\phi(x)} = \frac{M}{A}$$

When $M = A$, the elasticity equals 1.

Exercise 9.3

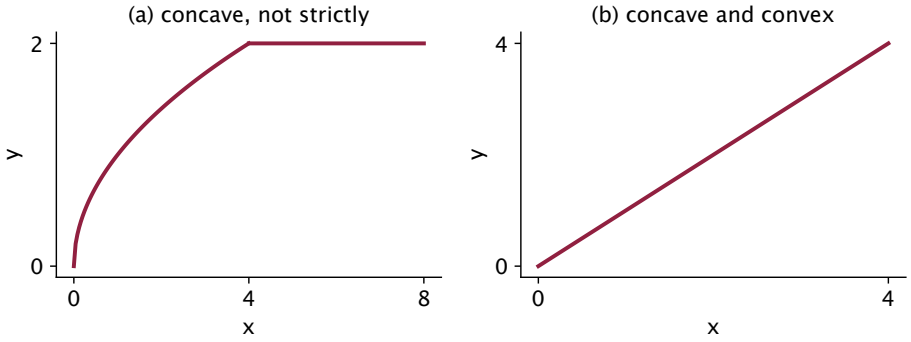
2. (a) $y = 9x^2 - 4x + 8$: $y' = 18x - 4$ and $y'' = 18 > 0$ for all x, so strictly convex.

(b) $w = -3x^2 + 39$: $w' = -6x$ and $w'' = -6 < 0$, so strictly concave, not convex.

(c) $u = 9 - 2x^2$: $u' = -4x$ and $u'' = -4 < 0$, so strictly concave, not convex.

(d) $v = 8 - 5x + x^2$: $v' = -5 + 2x$ and $v'' = 2 > 0$, so strictly convex.

3. (a) Any concave curve that contains a straight segment, for example $y = \sqrt{x}$ for $0 \le x \le 4$ continued as the horizontal line $y = 2$ for $x > 4$. (b) A straight line, for example $y = x$: its second derivative is zero everywhere, so it satisfies both $f'' \le 0$ and $f'' \ge 0$.



4. $y = a - \dfrac{b}{c + x}$

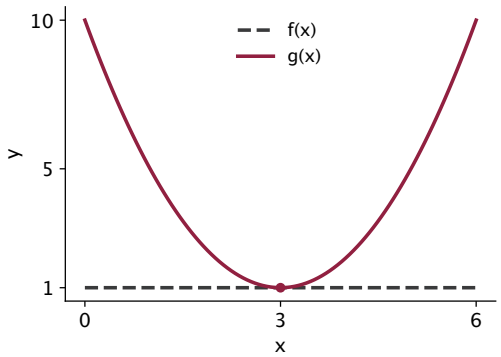
(a) $\dfrac{dy}{dx} = \dfrac{b}{(c+x)^2} > 0$ and $\dfrac{d^2y}{dx^2} = -\dfrac{2b}{(c+x)^3} < 0$, so the function is increasing and strictly concave.

(b) At $x = 0$, $y = a - b/c$.

(c) As $x \to \infty$, $b/(c+x) \to 0$, so $y \to a$. The graph rises from $a - b/c$ toward the horizontal asymptote $y = a$, flattening as it goes.

As a consumption function with income x: consumption should be positive at zero income, which requires $ac > b$, and the marginal propensity to consume dy/dx should be less than 1 at every income level, which requires $b/c^2 < 1$, that is, $b < c^2$.

5. $f(x)$ must be a constant, say $f(x) = 1$; every point is a stationary point. $g(x)$ could be $g(x) = x^2 - 6x + 10$, which has a single stationary point at $x = 3$. The difference: f is stationary everywhere, whereas g is stationary only at $x = 3$.



Exercise 9.4

1. (b) $y = x^3 + 6x^2 + 9$

$$y' = 3x^2 + 12x = 3x(x+4) = 0 \implies x^* = 0, -4; \qquad y'' = 6x + 12$$

$y''(0) = 12 > 0$, so $y(0) = 9$ is a relative minimum. $y''(-4) = -12 < 0$, so $y(-4) = 41$ is a relative maximum.

(d) $y = \dfrac{2x}{1-2x}$. By the quotient rule,

$$y' = \frac{2(1-2x) - 2x(-2)}{(1-2x)^2} = \frac{2}{(1-2x)^2}$$

which is never zero. There is no stationary point, so there are no relative extrema. The function is increasing on each side of $x = 1/2$.

2. Let L be the side parallel to the wall and W the two sides perpendicular to it. The netting constraint is $L + 2W = 64$, so $L = 64 - 2W$ and the area is

$$A = LW = (64 - 2W)W = 64W - 2W^2$$

$$\frac{dA}{dW} = 64 - 4W = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; W^* = 16, \quad L^* = 32$$

Since $d^2A/dW^2 = -4 < 0$, this is a maximum (the area function is strictly concave, so it is the global maximum). The largest area is $32 \times 16 = 512$ square feet.

3. (a) Yes: $a = 1/3 > 0$, $b = -7 < 0$, $c = 111 > 0$, $d = 50 > 0$, and $b^2 = 49 < 3ac = 111$.

   (b) From the demand function, $P = 100 - Q$, so $R = PQ = (100-Q)Q = 100Q - Q^2$.

   (c) $\pi = R - C = 100Q - Q^2 - \frac{1}{3}Q^3 + 7Q^2 - 111Q - 50 = -\frac{1}{3}Q^3 + 6Q^2 - 11Q - 50$

   (d)
   $$\frac{d\pi}{dQ} = -Q^2 + 12Q - 11 = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; (Q-1)(Q-11) = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; Q = 1 \text{ or } 11$$
   $\frac{d^2\pi}{dQ^2} = -2Q + 12$ is $10 > 0$ at $Q = 1$ (a minimum) and $-10 < 0$ at $Q = 11$ (a maximum). So $Q^* = 11$.

   (e) $\pi(11) = -\frac{1}{3}(1331) + 6(121) - 11(11) - 50 = 334/3 \approx 111.33$.

5. $\pi(Q) = hQ^2 + jQ + k$

   (a) $\pi(0) = k$, so $k < 0$.

   (b) $\pi'(Q) = 2hQ + j$ and $\pi''(Q) = 2h$, so strict concavity requires $h < 0$.

   (c) The critical point is $Q^* = -j/(2h)$. With $h < 0$, we need $j > 0$ to make $Q^* > 0$.